

K-12 ASSESSMENT AND GRADING COMMON GUIDELINES

Loudoun County Public Schools' (LCPS) philosophy regarding assessment and grading is based on teachers' collective belief in a growth mindset. Students master concepts and skills in different ways and at different rates. Though the primary outcome of grading and assessment is a reflection of mastery, it also reflects a student's motivation and work ethic towards that outcome. Teachers are responsible for developing instructional plans based on frequent and varied assessments. Grades shall not reflect behavior in the classroom but rather a student's mastery of content or competencies of the curriculum.

The *Elementary Grading Procedures* document and the *Elementary Report Card* manual outline the assessment and grading practices for grades K-5.

A. Special Populations. Recognizing that students learn at different paces, teachers and support teams should collaborate to provide necessary assistance to learners who may require it, including English Learners, Students with Disabilities, and students with 504 Plans.

1. Teachers are required to adhere to the assignment and assessment modifications and accommodations specified in students' Individualized Education Plans (IEPs) and 504 Plans.

2. Accommodations or alternative assessment approaches should be considered when assessing English Learners to accurately measure the student's progress and content mastery.

B. Gradebook and Grading Timeline. Teachers must include the following categories in their gradebook: formative assessments, minor summative assessments, major summative assessments, and extra credit (optional).

1. Quarter Grades - Students who put forth a reasonable effort throughout the quarter will receive a grade that is no lower than 50% for quarters 1, 2, & 3 in high school courses—and all quarters in middle school courses.

- a. The floor of 50% does not apply to the final quarter of a high school course. Moreover, the floor does not apply to the final quarter of a semester course.

- b. The floor of 50% does not apply to Advanced Placement (AP) courses.

- c. Notwithstanding the above, if teachers believe a student has not put forth reasonable effort throughout the quarter, they may, in consultation with student support teams and parents, give a quarter grade that is less than 50%.

2. There are no midterm or final exams.

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3. Teachers must record in the gradebook and provide feedback to students on all assessments within six consecutive school days from the date the assignment is collected. Grades for complex middle school or high school summative assessments/assignments, such as research papers, that require analysis or detailed feedback, shall be entered into the gradebook within 10 consecutive school days from the date the assignment is collected.

4. For high school courses, the semester grade is calculated by averaging the two quarter grades within that semester. A student's final grade is calculated by averaging the two semester grades.

5. For middle school courses, the final grade is calculated by averaging the grades from quarters 1, 2, 3, and 4.

C. Reasonable Effort. Reasonable effort occurs when a student submits an assignment, formative assessment, or summative assessment in which they have made an attempt to complete it using the information provided during instruction.

1. Students should attempt to complete each part of an assignment, formative assessment, or summative assessment.

2. If a student is not able to complete part of an assignment or formative assessment because they do not understand the content, they should request assistance from the teacher.

3. Examples of students not demonstrating reasonable effort on assignments, formative assessments, or summative assessments include simply writing their name without attempting any other part, writing "Don't Know" for every question, repeating the same answer throughout the assignment, formative assessment, or summative assessment.

D. Homework. Homework is a natural extension of the school day and can be practice or reinforcement. Given that homework is considered practice and/or application with an opportunity for feedback, it is considered a formative assessment.

1. Teachers will use homework as an opportunity to learn more about the instructional needs of each student and use it to provide feedback for growth and learning.

2. Teachers will base all homework on one or more of the following:

- a. To prepare for, relate to, build upon, reinforce and/or enhance learning in the classroom.
- b. To practice skills that have been introduced and developed in class.

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- c. To relate understandings and skills developed at school to everyday life.
 - d. To enrich the school program by pursuing activities that can be shared with classmates the following day.
 - e. To provide for independent study or projects.
 - f. To complete unfinished classroom assignments or projects.
3. Teachers will consider the resources available to all students when assigning homework.
4. Students will view homework as an opportunity to practice their skills and will complete all homework assignments and formative assessments by their due date.
5. Students will request additional help and/or clarification of assignments from the teacher in order to complete assignments to the best of their ability and in a timely manner.
6. Students will obtain and complete assignments missed due to being absent.
7. Middle and high school teachers may assign long-term assignments such as reports and projects that are completed outside the classroom, and they may be considered summative assessments and are, therefore, graded. These may be considered major assessments and may count between 10% and 25% of the quarter grade.
8. If homework is to be used as a summative assessment, at least one formative assessment must precede this grade, and it must be graded for accuracy.
9. Any homework assigned to students must be something the students are able to complete successfully on their own in a reasonable amount of time.
- a. For elementary students in grades 1-3, students should spend no more than 30 minutes daily on homework. For students in grades 4- 5, students should spend no more than sixty (60) minutes daily on homework.
 - b. For middle and high school students, the time students spend on homework will reflect the expectations and level of the course. For example, Honors, Dual Enrollment, and Advanced Placement courses will require more time.
- E. Formative Assessment. A formative assessment is an assessment for learning that occurs during the learning process and is designed to guide the next steps toward mastery. The goal of formative assessments is to monitor learning, provide feedback to students, and set goals to move learning forward. Information gathered during formative assessment is used

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to inform the next steps in instruction. Completion of all formative assessments and homework assignments throughout the quarter may be applied to no more than 10% (to include completion and reasonable effort when appropriate) of the quarter grade.

1. Formative feedback informs the learner, teacher, and parents/guardians about progress toward mastery of the concept or skill.
2. Formative assessments must precede each summative assessment. Teachers must include formative assessments in their lesson planning and provide students feedback about their progress toward mastery prior to a summative assessment.
3. All feedback should be specific, clear, consistent, and actionable.
4. Feedback on formative assessments should be provided to students with enough time for them to master the content prior to the associated summative assessment.
5. Formative assessment data must be used by teachers to identify areas of student strength and student growth. Teachers will use this data to adjust instruction accordingly.

F. Summative Assessment. A summative assessment is an assessment of learning that occurs at the end of a learning cycle and is designed to determine a student's level of mastery of specified content or competencies. Summative assessments become the source of information for grading.

1. Major summative assessments range between 10-25% of the quarter grade.
2. At least 1 major summative assessment should be administered each quarter.
3. Summative assessments that account for less than 10% of the quarter grades are minor summative assessments. Reassessments are not required for minor summative assessments.
4. Grade level and curriculum teams should create common summative assessments that are aligned to a common set of standards.
5. Teams should create rigorous and authentic opportunities for students to demonstrate and apply their learning in various ways.

G. Reassessments. Reassessments encourage a growth mindset in students and allow them to demonstrate mastery.

1. Teachers will provide one opportunity for reassessment of all **major** summative assessments for students who score below 70% and have demonstrated reasonable effort to

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complete all homework and formative assessments prior to the initial assessment. Teachers may need to provide additional academic support prior to reassessment.

2. Reassessments will only be available to students who have demonstrated reasonable effort during the initial assessment.

3. Teachers may not average the scores from the original assessment and the reassessment. The reassessment grade must not exceed 70%. A note must be added to the gradebook documenting the original score and the retake score.

4. The higher of the two scores (initial assessment or retake) will be used to calculate the quarter grade.

5. Teachers will ensure eligible students are aware of the reassessment opportunity.

6. Reassessments will be scheduled by the student in collaboration with the teacher and must take place within 10 consecutive school days after the student receives feedback from the original assessment and any necessary academic support.

7. The format of the reassessment does not need to mirror the format of the original assessment.

8. The reassessment may be limited to the standards not mastered by the student.

9. Teachers should utilize the resources available to them, such as their school's multi-tiered systems of support, when encouraging students to take advantage of the reassessment process.

10. There is no floor grade for initial assessments or reassessments.

11. When there is a pattern of multiple reassessments requested by a student, teachers, in consultation with student support teams and parents, may limit future opportunities for reassessment.

H. Late Work. Teachers accept late work to document learning and inform instruction prior to the administration of a major summative assessment. Reasonable and consistent guidelines for accepting late work must be set and communicated to students.

1. Deadlines should be required for submitting late work.

2. Late work will not be accepted after the major summative assessment that is associated with the assignments or formative assessments has been completed.

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I. Academic Integrity. Students are expected to perform honestly on all schoolwork and assessments.

1. If dishonesty is determined, students may complete an alternative summative assessment to demonstrate their learning within six consecutive school days after the student receives the feedback. There will not be an opportunity for a reassessment of the alternative summative assessment.

2. Teachers working with one or more of the following parties (parents, student, counselor, or administrator) will create an academic Recovery Plan. It may include a parent-teacher conference, retaking the assessment, an alternative assessment, a lowering of the grade, or receiving a failing grade.

3. Teachers should clearly define expectations regarding collaborative and independent work, reinforce behavioral expectations regarding dishonesty in assigned work, provide feedback throughout the learning process or the assignment timeline, and take reasonable action to maintain assessment and test security.

4. The following actions are prohibited:

- a. Cheating on an assessment or assigned work by giving, receiving, offering and/or soliciting information.
- b. Plagiarizing by copying the language, structure, idea, and/or thoughts of another.
- c. Falsifying statements on any assigned schoolwork, tests, or other school documents.
- d. Knowingly utilizing generative artificial intelligence (AI) on an assignment is prohibited unless directed to do so by the teacher or as a documented accommodation or assistive technology in a student's Section 504 Plan or Individualized Education Plan.

5. Teachers should take the following actions:

- a. Clearly define expectations regarding dishonesty in assigned work.
- b. Reinforce behavioral expectations regarding dishonesty in assigned work.
- c. Provide feedback throughout the learning process or the assignment timeline.

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- d. Take reasonable actions to maintain assessment and test security.
- J. Extra Credit. Extra Credit is a Collaborative Learning Team (CLT) or department choice and must be connected to the course content curriculum and specific learning goals.
 - 1. If predetermined by the CLT or department, the gradebook may include extra credit (cannot exceed 3% of the quarter grade) and must be based on accuracy and content.
 - 2. Extra credit must be available to all students when it is offered.
 - 3. Students are not able to obtain a quarter or semester grade greater than 100%.
- K. Dual Enrollment. Dual Enrollment (DE) courses must meet the unique grading, assessment, and withdrawal policies as specified by the accrediting college or university.
 - 1. Teachers and counselors should inform parents and students of the accrediting college's or university's policies before and during the course selection process.
 - 2. Teachers of DE courses must provide a course syllabus with assessment, grading, and withdrawal guidelines to all students and their parents at the beginning of each semester.
 - 3. Students participating in courses offered by an institution of higher education are permitted to exceed a full course load in order to participate in courses that lead to a degree, certificate, or credential at such institution.
- L. Expectations. Common expectations for secondary workload:
 - 1. No assignment or homework will be due or assigned on Saturday or Sunday, student holidays, or any other day that school is not in session.
 - 2. Summative assessments should take a student no more than a class period with the exception of:
 - a. Long-term reports and assignments completed outside of school.
 - b. Alternative assessments.
 - c. Performance assessments (such as projects).

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Legal Refs: Code of Virginia, 1950, as amended, §§ 22.1-78, 22.1-253.13:1, 8 VAC 20-131-140.